The Financial Engineering Essential for AI in 2027

By Tomasz Tunguz · @ttunguz · November 3, 2026

Mr. Pickles Lanman's TLDR:

Mixed

- Anthropic's amended IPO filing shows it bought $5.0 billion of short-term compute in Q3 2026, and that compute cost much more than capacity under its multi-year deals.
- The author estimates Anthropic's average cost per GPU-hour rose from $3.10 to $5.65 in six months, driven by short-term prices of $12 to $13 an hour.
- Price competition makes it hard for AI labs to pass higher costs on to customers.
- Labs are responding by making models more efficient, tightening subscription limits and moving big customers onto multi-year contracts.
- The author argues the 2027 winners will be labs whose customer contracts last as long as their compute leases.

TRUTH CHECK The filing backs the core story: costly short-term compute flipped Q3 to an operating loss, and Opus 5.5 and the OpenAI limit change are real. But every per-hour GPU price is the author's own estimate, not 'data from the S-1/A'. The headline 'more than doubled' overstates his own blended figure (+82%), and the $12 to $13 figures are the top of his estimated ranges.

Serif text is the author's, unchanged. Underlines and numbers point to Pickles' margin notes.

The essential ingredient to AI has more than doubled in the last 6 months. In 2026, the race was to find GPUs at any price. In 2027, the winners will be the labs that match the duration of their customers' contracts to the duration of their compute.

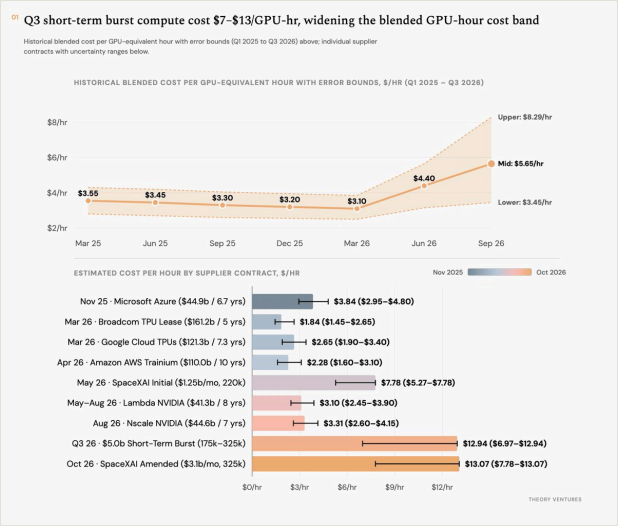
The essential ingredient to AI has more than doubled in cost in the last 6 months.[1]

1 · TRUTH CHECK: MISLEADING

His own chart says 82%

The author's blended cost goes from $3.10 to $5.65. That is an 82% rise, not a doubling. His lower bound, $3.45, is barely above where it started. Only the short-term burst price, a slice of total compute, more than doubled. The headline picks the most dramatic number.

Tunguz post with footnotes



GPUs, the chips that power AI, have increased in rental price per hour from $3 to $12 to $13 on short-term contracts[2], pushing Anthropic's blended cost per GPU-equivalent hour from $3.10 to $5.65 (within a $3.45 to $8.29 confidence band), according to data from the updated Anthropic S-1/A[3].

Anthropic, like other AI providers, is trying to rent as many accelerators as possible on multi-year contracts that fix prices around $2 to $4 per hour. When that long-term capacity is exhausted, AI vendors must buy access to GPUs[4] in the short-term burst market, where prices have surged.

This cost spike changes the unit economics of a frontier lab. A doubling of GPU cost must be met by a doubling of model efficiency[5], a doubling of price to the customer, or a combination of the two to preserve margins.

2 · TRUTH CHECK: MISLEADING

$12 to $13 is the top

In the chart, $12.94 sits at the very top of its own range ($6.97 to $12.94). So does $13.07 ($7.78 to $13.07). The $13.07 divides SpaceX's amended $3.1B a month by 325,000 GPUs. That count belongs to the original $1.25B deal, and no GPU count was disclosed for the amended terms. The B300 chip's median on-demand list price was $8.38.

FourWeekMBA on SpaceX deal · AMCompute B300 prices

3 · TRUTH CHECK: MISLEADING

The filing has no hourly prices

The S-1/A gives contract totals and terms. It gives no per-hour prices and no GPU counts. The $3.10, $5.65 and the confidence band are the author's estimates. He built them from the filing, a SpaceX prospectus and a private price index. His own footnote says so, but this sentence reads as if Anthropic disclosed them.

FourWeekMBA on S-1/A · Cape Fear Advisors

4 · TRUTH CHECK: CONFIRMED

The core mechanism is real

The filing says $5.0B of short-term compute 'currently costs significantly more' than multi-year compute. It also says this drove a swing from $974M operating income in Q2 to a $567M loss in Q3. That was about half of Q3's $9.9B compute bill. The $2 to $4 long-term range is still the author's estimate.

PPC Land on S-1/A · The Next Web

5 · PICKLES' TAKE

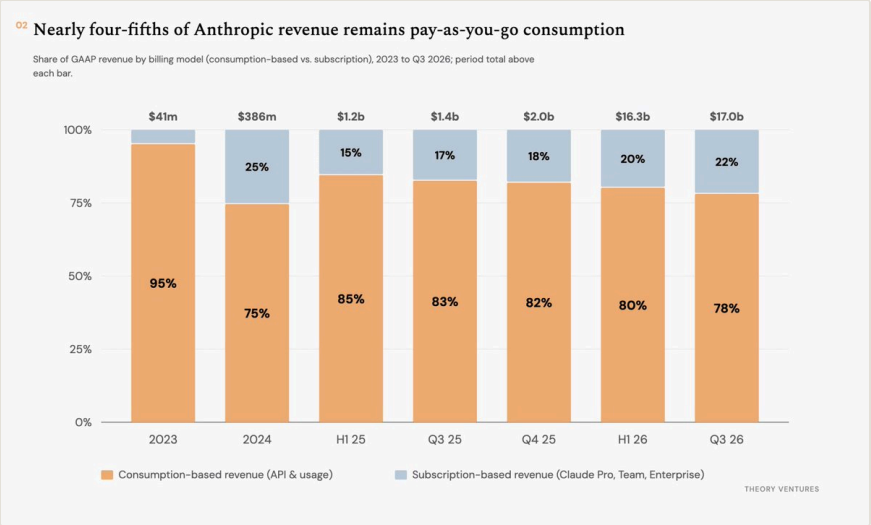
The math is overstated

This only works if GPUs were the lab's entire cost. Compute was 58% of Anthropic's Q3 revenue, and some of it goes to training rather than serving customers. Doubling the compute cost behind each sale does not require doubling prices to protect margins. The pressure is real, but smaller than this sentence implies.

The Next Web

With 40% to 50% of data center projects delayed & billions of dollars of GPUs[6] sitting idle in warehouses waiting for power, plus transformer & turbine lead times measured in years, this supply pressure shows no sign of easing in the near term.

Meanwhile, the price war across frontier & mid-tier models makes raising token prices perilous[7] : any lab that hikes rates cedes share.



Labs are responding on three fronts : engineering step-function gains in model efficiency like Opus 5.5's 40% reduction in cost per task over Opus 5[8], tightening subscription allowances like OpenAI's move to pool ChatGPT & Codex into a single shared token limit[9], & pushing enterprise buyers from serverless API consumption into multi-year committed contracts[10].

6 · PICKLES' TAKE
A forecast, stated as fact
The author's footnote sources the 40% to 50% to Goldman Sachs. Goldman forecast that only 50% to 60% of planned capacity comes online on time over one to two years. That is a forecast about capacity, not a count of projects already delayed. The claim about warehouses full of idle GPUs has no source at all.
Tunguz footnotes

7 · TRUTH CHECK: CONFIRMED
Anthropic is cutting prices
The filing supports this. It reports revenue about $600M lower in Q3 because of price reductions. Opus 5.5 also launched with per-token prices 20% below Opus 5. So the lab is lowering prices at the same moment its compute costs are rising.
PPC Land on S-1/A · Anthropic Opus 5.5

8 · TRUTH CHECK: CONFIRMED
True, with fine print
Anthropic says Opus 5.5 costs 40% less than Opus 5 'on typical workloads' at default settings, based on its own tests. Part of that saving is a per-token price cut, not just efficiency. That is the customer getting cheaper prices, which runs against the margin story.
Anthropic Opus 5.5

9 · TRUTH CHECK: CONFIRMED
Real, starting in December
OpenAI says Plus, Pro and Business plans will share one token-based allowance across ChatGPT and Codex starting in December. OpenAI ties the change to merging its 'Work' agent features into ChatGPT, not to cost. Calling it 'tightening' is fair but is the author's interpretation.
Notebookcheck

10 · TRUTH CHECK: CONFIRMED

Usage billing still dominates

Chart 2 matches the filing. Usage-based revenue was 79% of the first nine months of 2026. That does not prove all of it is uncommitted 'pay-as-you-go', because some enterprise API deals carry spending minimums and are still billed by usage. The chart does not separate those out.

PPC Land on S-1/A

Financial engineering in 2027 means closing that duration mismatch : selling a Fortune 500 buyer a multi-year minimum commitment at a locked-in rate[11] to match the duration of the GPU lease underneath it.

11 · PICKLES' TAKE

Sharp insight, with a catch

The mismatch is real. One analysis counts about $825.6B of compute bills due after 12 months against about $3.45B of customer obligations. But the costly SpaceXAI capacity can be cancelled on 90 days' notice from early 2027. Locking customers into fixed rates now could backfire if burst prices fall.

FourWeekMBA on S-1/A · PPC Land on S-1/A

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